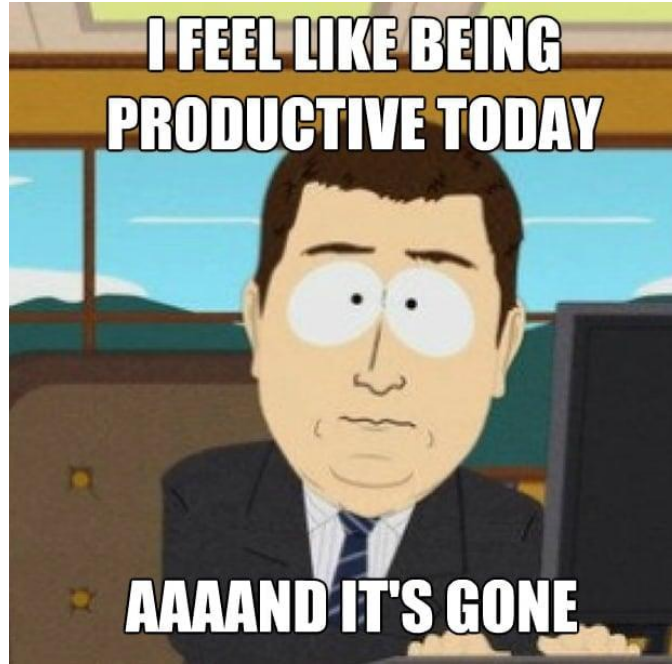


Every engineer must get stuff done

... but it's too easy being a blob 🤪



I'm Alex

- My goal: **Teach you how to get more stuff done with less time**
💪
- High-performing tech lead across Meta and Robinhood working 30 - 40 hour weeks
- \$85k TC -> \$750k TC in 7 years
- Able to sustain a healthy personal life outside of work 😊



Alex's Stats (Per Half)

Code written: ~275 commits (Top 5%)

Code reviewed: ~725 commits (Top 1%)

Helping others: 100+ public thanks per half

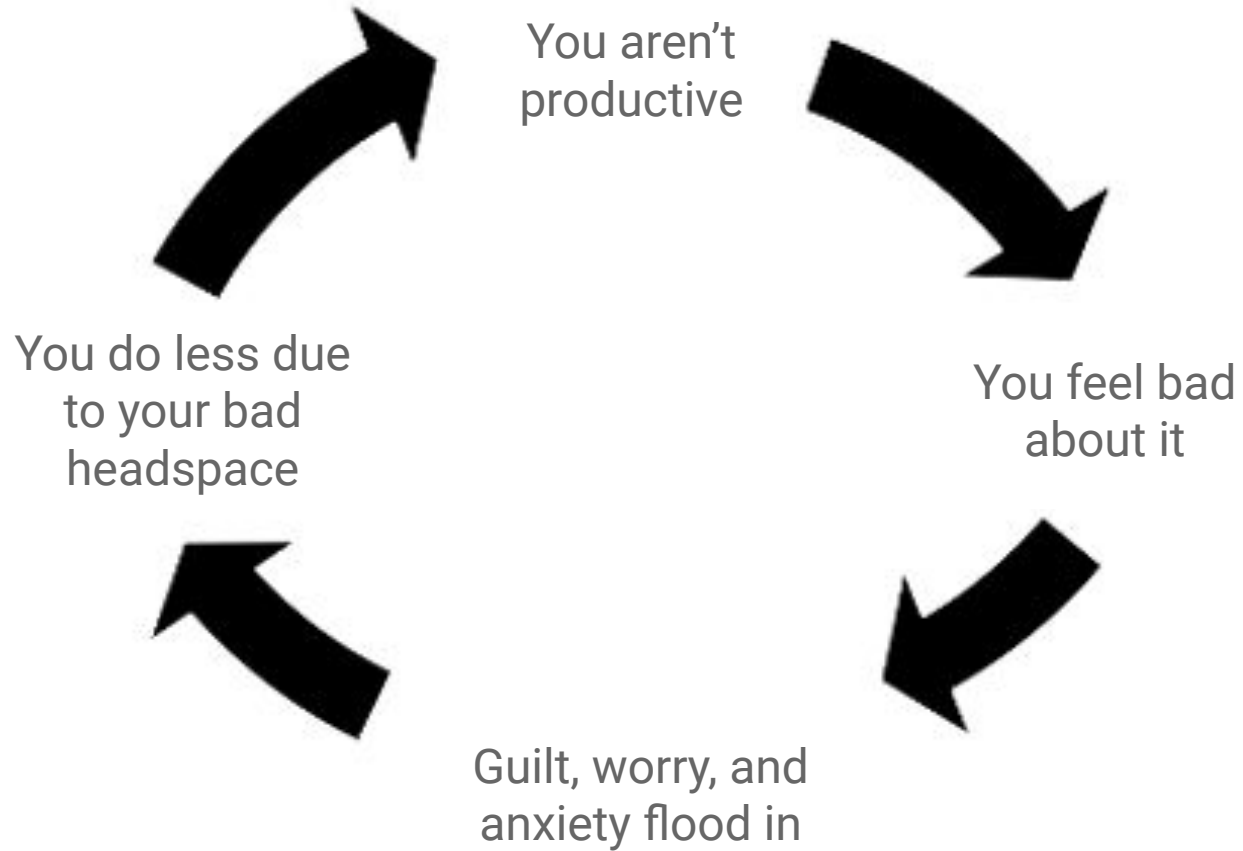
Mentorship: Got ~5 engineers promoted

*This is why Alex got Exceeds Expectations or higher every performance review 🚀



Software
Engineers







Objectives

-  Teach you the **true** most important productivity booster
-  Champion the right **mentality** to foster productivity
-  Use the right tactics to **move faster**
-  Have shields to prevent you from **wasting time**
-  Learn how to **debug** a lack of productivity

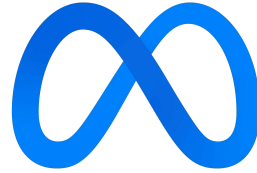
The Productivity Giant You Are Missing



Software = *Disproportionate* Outcomes



Spent years and billions of \$\$\$
in engineering hours to make
Google+, a complete disaster



Creates the Facebook Like in
a hackathon, one of the most
influential features of all time

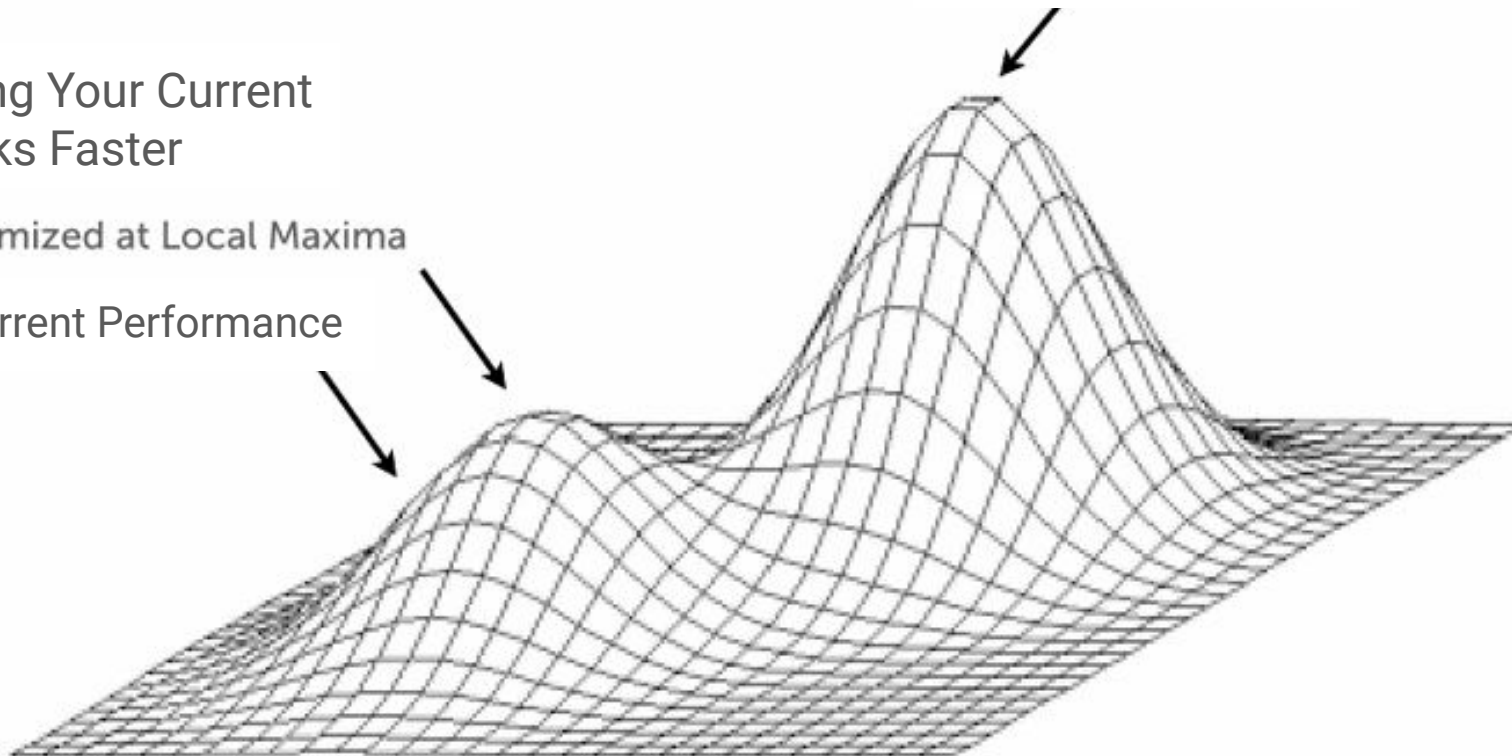


Doing Your Current
Tasks Faster

Optimized at Local Maxima

Current Performance

Working On The
Right Tasks



**WORK ON
TASKS
INEFFICIENTLY**



**WORK ON
TASKS
EFFICIENTLY**



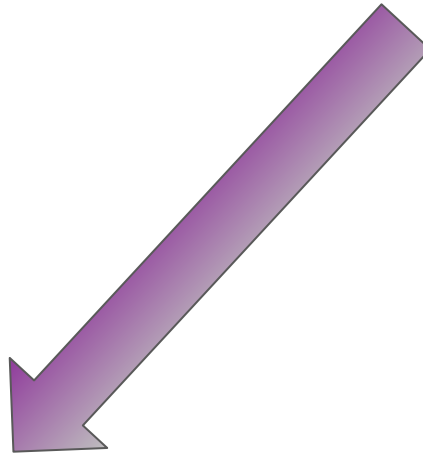
**WORK ON
THE RIGHT TASKS
INEFFICIENTLY**



**WORK ON
THE RIGHT
TASKS EFFICIENTLY**



Let's get you here 💪🚀



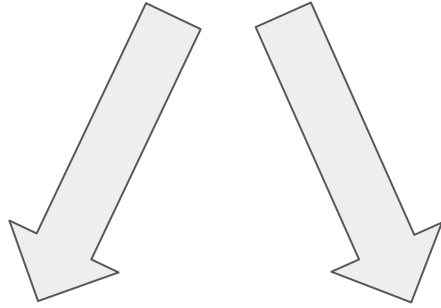
**Make sure you're working on the
right things.**

Finding The Best Things To Work On





Task



Impact

Time
Required

Figure out these 2 attributes for all your tasks. 🖋️

After that, let's do some math 🧮

High impact (3)

Mid impact (2)

Low impact (1)

Low time
cost (3)

9

6

3

Mid time
cost (2)

6

4

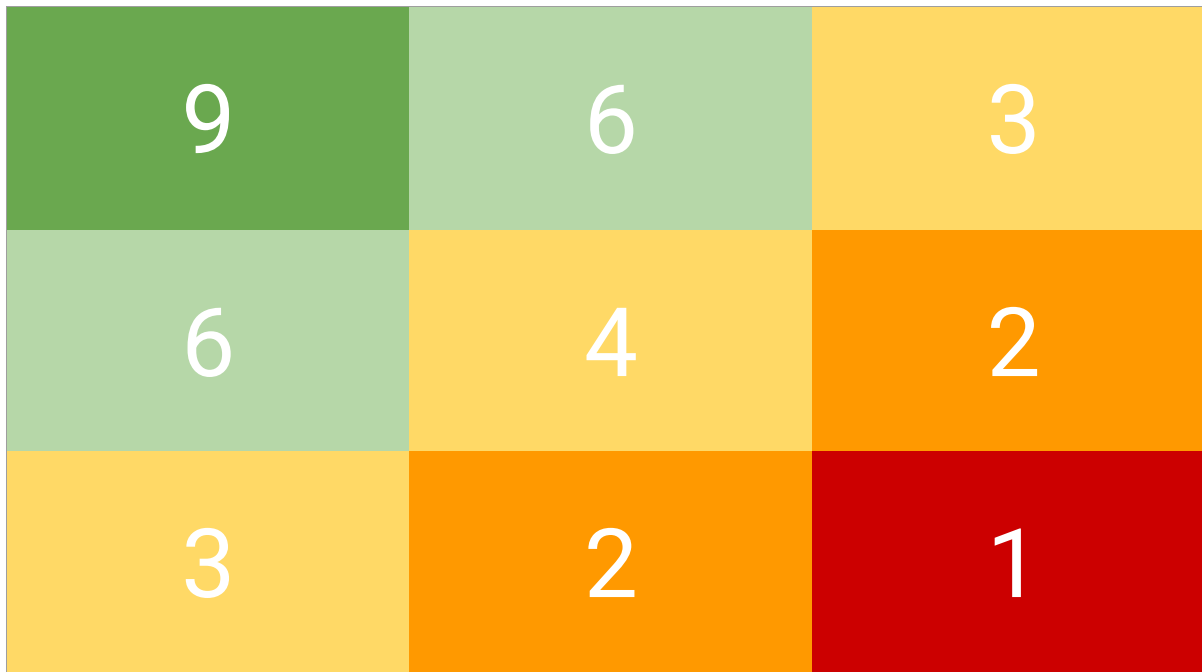
2

High time
cost (1)

3

2

1



You



"I went through all my tasks and prioritized them into this list. What do you think?"

Your Manager

"Thanks for putting this together! I would swap #2 and #3."

Do this every 1-3 months 

Alignment is key to success 

**It isn't ruthless prioritization
unless it feels painful.**

Stay The Course

A photograph of a sailboat on the water, taken from a low angle looking up at the mast and sails. The sky is a mix of blue and orange, suggesting sunset or sunrise. The water is dark blue with some whitecaps. A semi-transparent white box with rounded corners is centered over the image, containing the text "Stay the Course!".

Stay the
Course!



Learn To Push Back 🙌

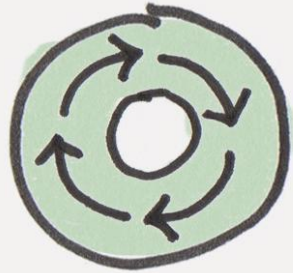
"That sounds like a great initiative! Unfortunately, I'm completely swamped right now with XYZ, so I can't help for a while. If you need me to prioritize this, feel free to start a conversation with us and my manager."

— Positive acknowledgement

— Honest pushback

— Keep the door open

Focus On The System



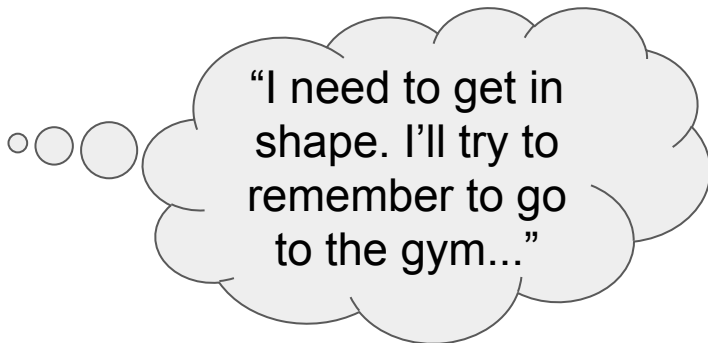
vs.



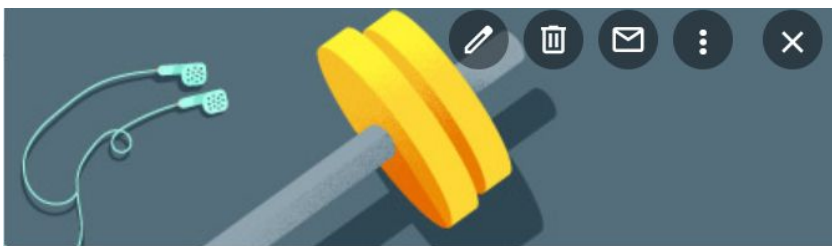


Willpower is *unreliable*, changing day to day 👎

Create a *system* to enforce productivity 👍



Systems take *energy* to break through 💡



GO TO THE GYM YOU LAZY BUM

Wednesday, July 17 · 9:00 – 10:00am

Weekly on Monday, Wednesday, Friday

[Invite via link](#)

 30 minutes before

 Alexander Chiou

WED

17

THU

18

FRI

19

GO TO THE GYM YOU
9 – 10am

GO TO THE GYM YOU
9 – 10am

**Make it easy to do the right thing and
hard to do the wrong thing.**

Social Pressure > Work Pressure

ACCOUNTABILITY PARTNERS





You

*"Oh shoot, I better
get stuff done."*



Someone You
Care About

Surround yourself with people who
you don't want to let down 🙏

So how can you apply social
pressure to yourself? 🤔

Tactic 1: Go Into The Office 🏢



Tactic 2: Virtual Coworking 🧑💻



Get Good Sleep

Me trying to get 8 hrs of sleep in just 3 hrs



You

"I've been pretty busy with work, so I've been sacrificing sleep to get more work done."

Your Peer

"Makes sense, I respect the grind."



You

"I've been pretty busy with work, so I stopped showering and brushing my teeth to save time."

Your Peer

*"What?!? That's disgusting. Personal hygiene is something you **make** time for. Get your priorities straight."*

Make Sleep 30%+ Of Your Life

- *There is no such thing as catching up on sleep*
 - Damage from sleep loss is permanent
- Sleep is your body's core natural recovery mechanism
 - Preserves mental acuity (very important for SWE)
- Sleep = 1 step backward, 5 steps forward

WARNING!

**LET YOUR BRAIN
RELAX, GET SOME
SLEEP.**

BENEFITS OF GOOD SLEEP

Sufficient sleep can help you:

- Reduce the frequency of getting sick
- Maintain a healthy weight
- Reduce the risk of serious health issues like diabetes and heart disease
- Lower stress and elevate your mood
- Sharpen your thought process, enabling you to perform well in class or at work
- Interact better with others
- Make wiser choices
- Reduce the risk of injuries



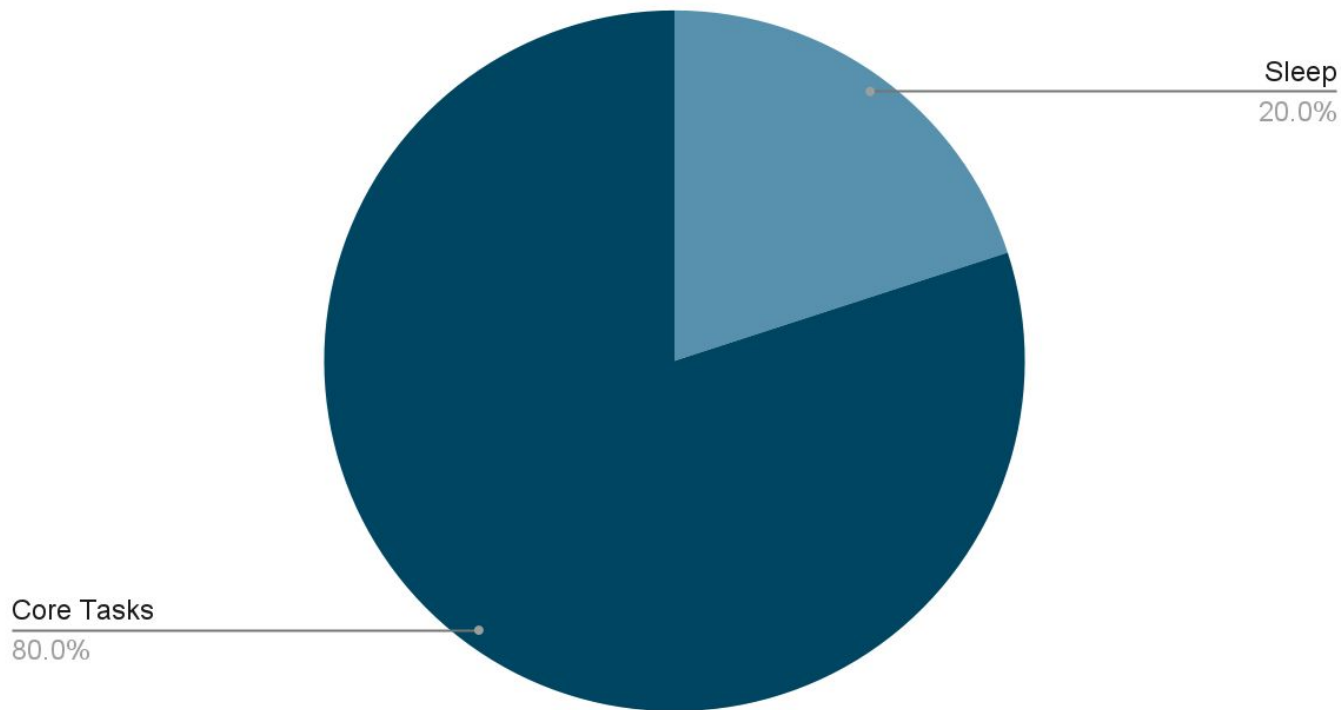
Sleep is a performance-enhancing drug

that is effectively *free* 💊

All you need to “pay” is time ⌚

Sleep-Deprived 🤔

Productivity (Time Spent %)



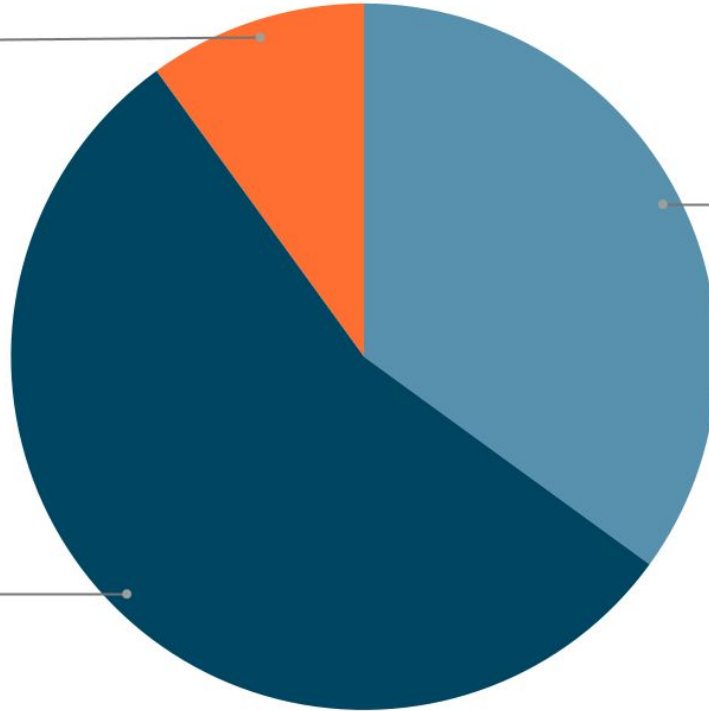
With Good Sleep 😊

Productivity (Time Spent %)

Bonus Tasks
10.0%

Core Tasks
55.0%

Sleep
35.0%



How To Get Good Sleep 🤪

- 1 Get 8+ hours
- 2 Sleep at a consistent time every night
- 3 Wake up naturally (alarm is failsafe)
- 4 Don't use screens 15+ minutes before bedtime
- 5 If you need additional help, take some melatonin

**Good sleep is something you *make*
time for.**

Touch Grass

How To
Touch
Grass



Please Go Outside

- Exercise is another core activity you *make* time for
- Being in natural light has enormous health benefits
- Physical health is deeply connected to your mental health
- Try to get 15-30 minutes of exercise 3-5 times a week



UNDERRATED BENEFITS OF EXERCISE



STRESS & ANXIETY
RELIEF



IMPROVED
FUNCTIONAL MOBILITY



INCREASED
ENERGY LEVELS



IMPROVED OVERALL
HEALTH



BETTER SLEEP



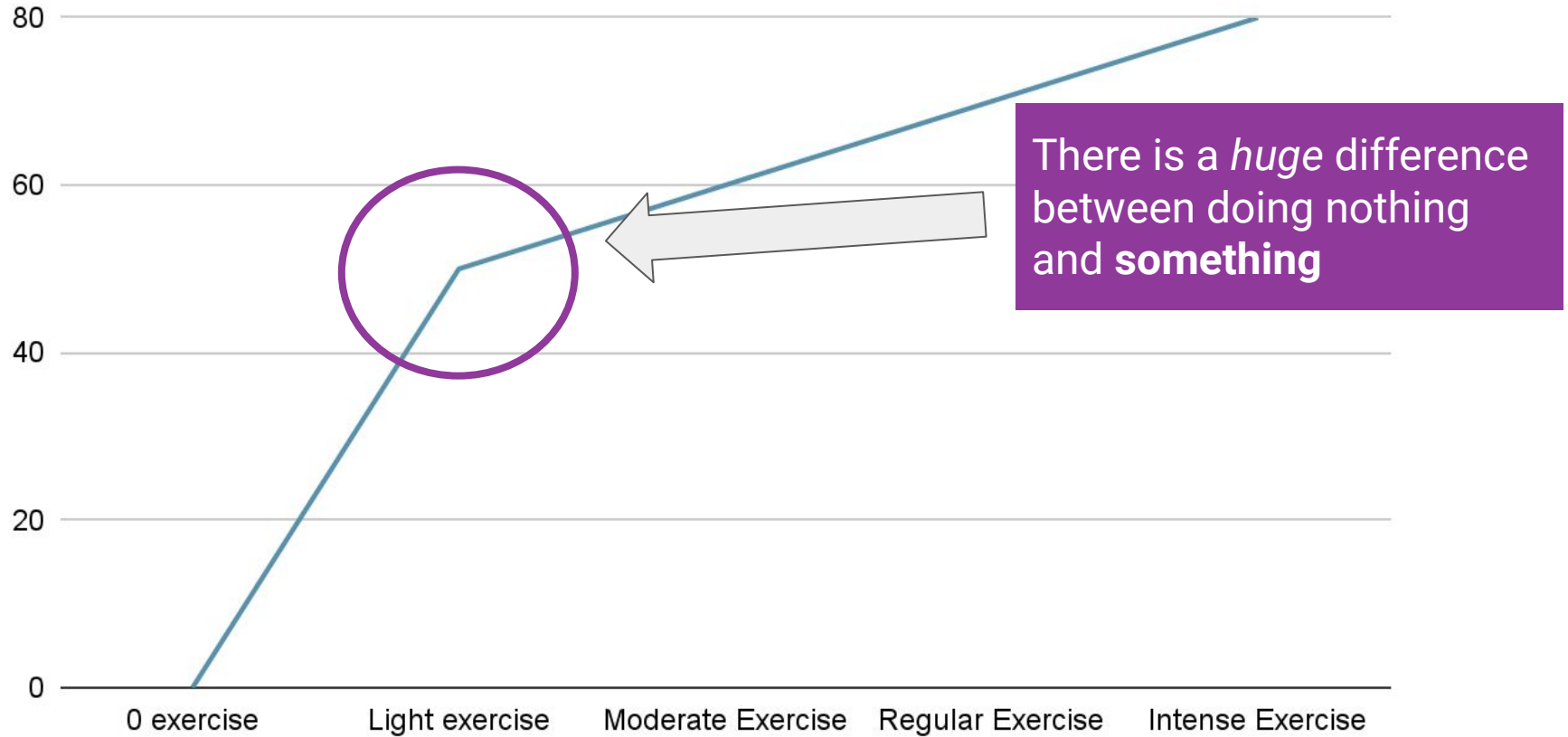
HIGHER
SELF-ESTEEM

Humans have evolved across millions of years to be active



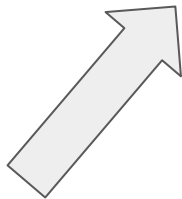
Fighting against your biology is a losing proposition **X**

Benefit Of Exercise On Your Health





If you get here, you
will almost certainly
follow through 💡



Move Faster

Focus Blocks





MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI
8	9	10	11	12
Write Code 9 – 10am	Write Code 9 – 10am	Write Code 9 – 10am	Write Code 9 – 10am	Write Code 9 – 10am



MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI
8	9	10	11	12
		Write Code 9am – 2pm		

The Many Startup Costs Of Coding

Pull main

Redeploy

Figure out how the
code works again

Switch
branches

Rebase and resolve
merge conflicts

Reread the
task

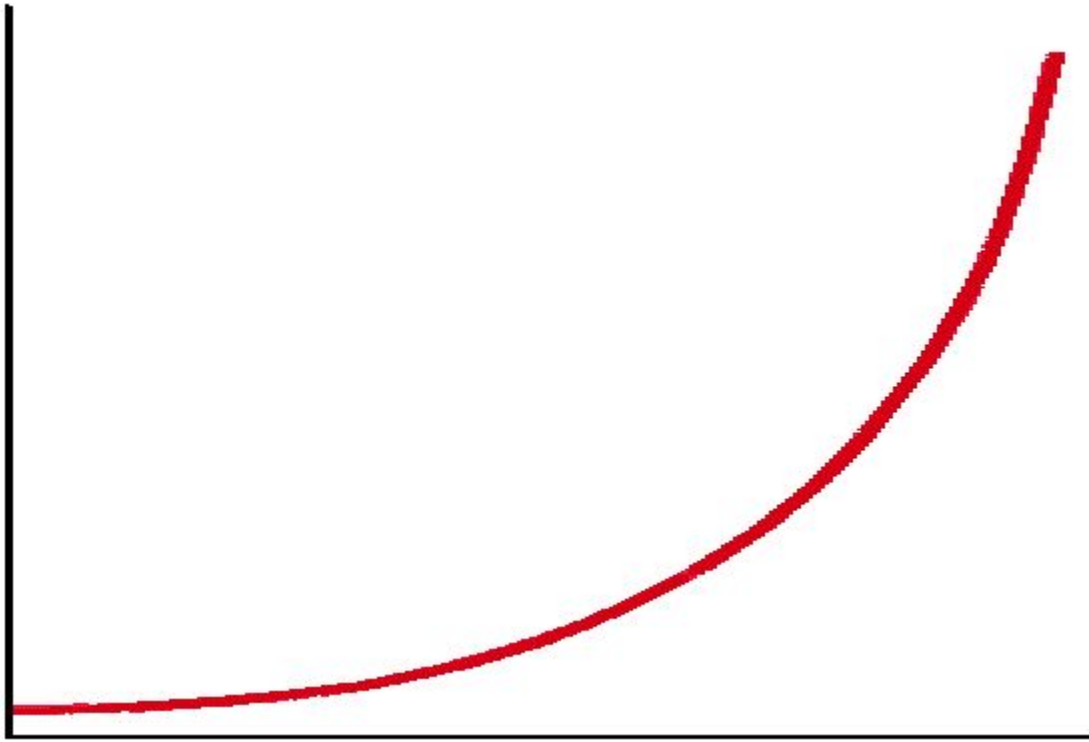
Fresh build

Reopen IDE

Fix bugs



Your
Productivity

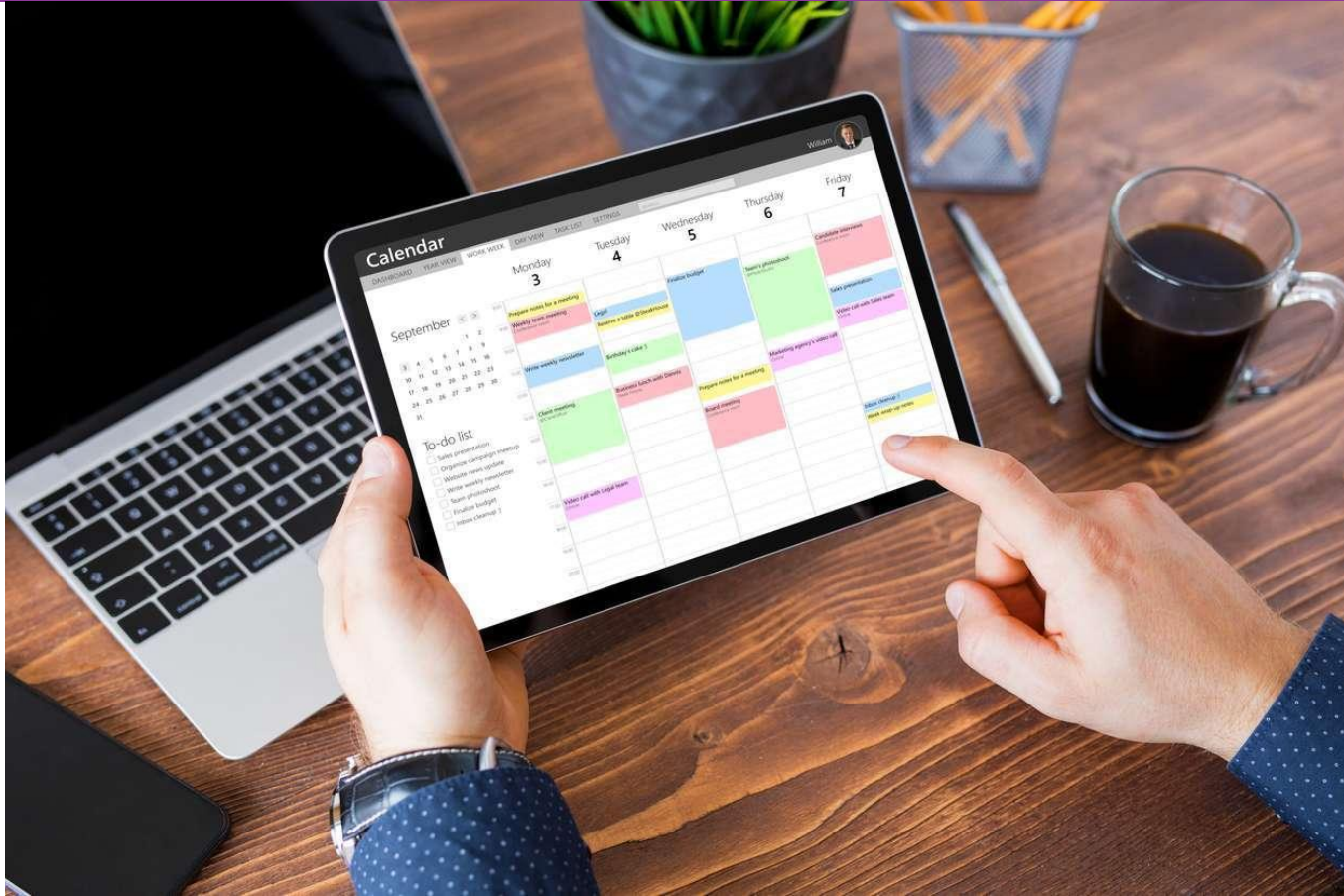


Uninterrupted Time Spent
Focusing On Work

There are few
things more
powerful than an
engineer who is in
the zone 💪

**You get the most done when you
have *momentum*.**

Organize Your Calendar



MON

8

TUE

9

WED

10

THU

11

FRI

12

Alex <> Rahul 1:1
9 – 10am



Alex <> Rahul 1:1
10 – 11am



Alex <> Rozie 1:1
8:30 – 9:30am

MON

15

TUE

16

WED

17

THU

18

FRI

19



Alex <> Rahul 1:1
9 – 10am

Alex <> Charlie 1 on
10 – 11am

Alex <> Rozie 1:1
11am – 12pm

Take Control Of What Takes Your Time 💪

- 1 Group certain types of meetings onto certain days
- 2 Try to have as many meetings back-to-back as possible
- 3 Clear large stretches of time for focus blocks

Not Every Meeting Needs You



Every meeting that you're in
takes away your most
valuable resource: **Time** 🕒

Be *extremely* careful with
what meetings you go to 🎯



Meeting

Which Meetings Should You Cut? ✂️

- ✖ *You've gone before and contributed nothing*
- ✖ You're marked as optional
- ✖ The meeting is **extremely** large
- ✖ You're redundant

Unsure? Run An A/B Test

A

Attend the meeting
and see how you
feel after. Did it
feel like a good
use of your time?

B

Skip the meeting,
catch up with the
meeting notes.
Can you still do
your job?



You

"Can I skip the weekly sync for project ABC? I haven't been on that project for 3 weeks now."

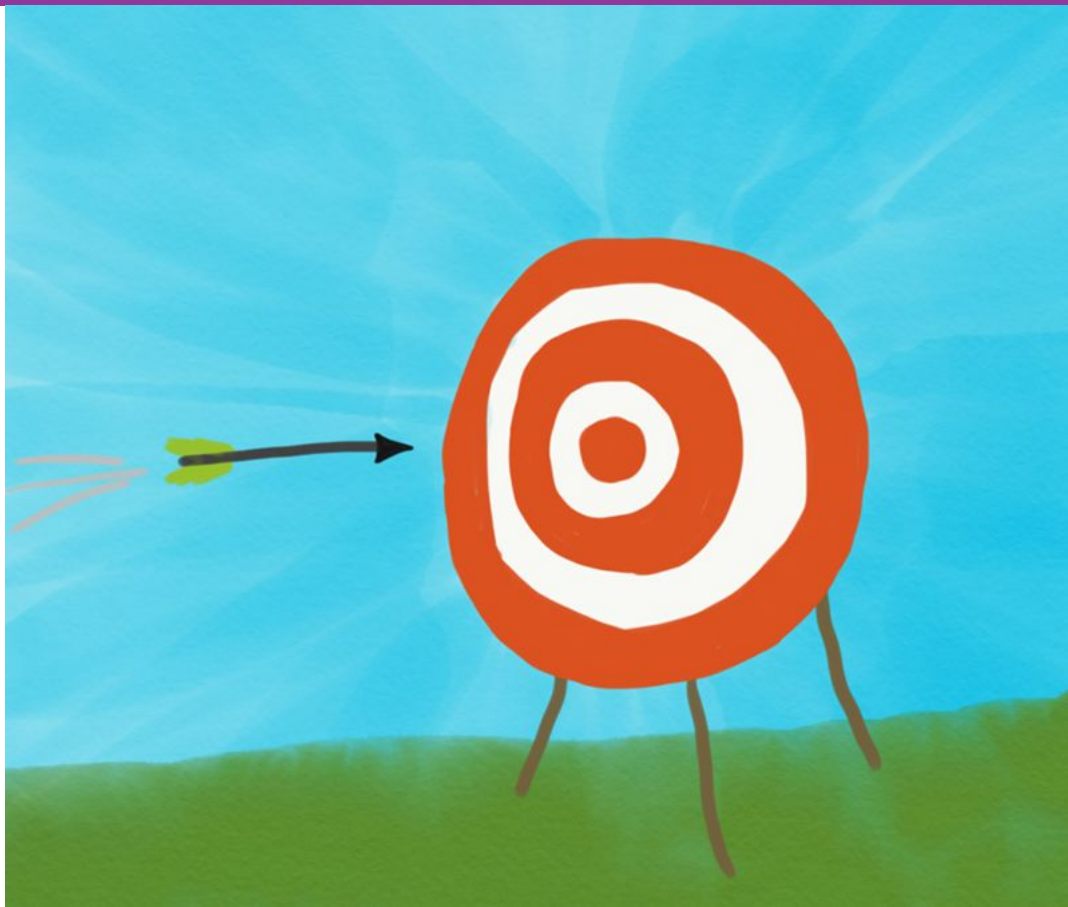


Your Manager

"Of course, I didn't even realize that you were still going."

Want to get permission to be safe? Just ask. 🙏

Just 1 Thing



Clear Out The Clutter

- *Every day, figure out the one most important task you need to do and solidify it*
 - Particularly on focus block days
 - Write it down
- Pretend other tasks don't exist while executing
- If you have multiple tasks, write them down in order



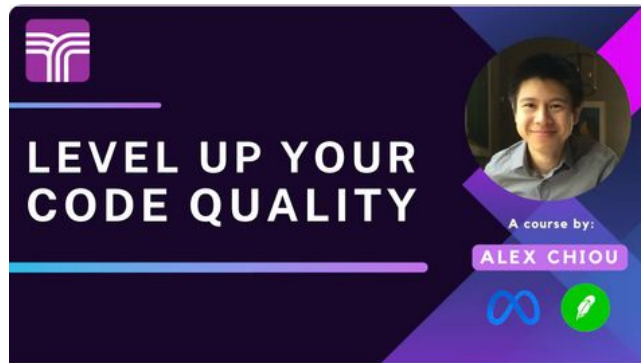
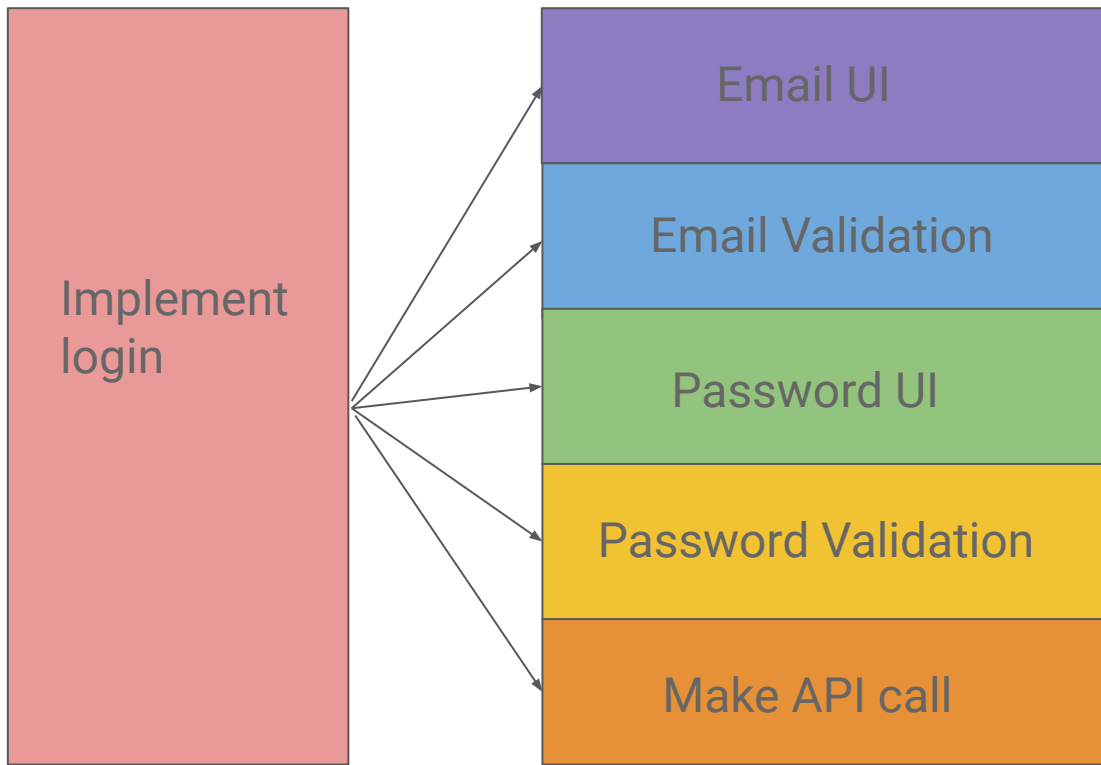
Make The System Hard To Ignore



Give yourself the gift of focus.

Decomposition





**Level Up Your Code Quality As A
Software Engineer**



Project



Milestone 1

Milestone 2

Milestone 3

Milestone 4

Milestone 5

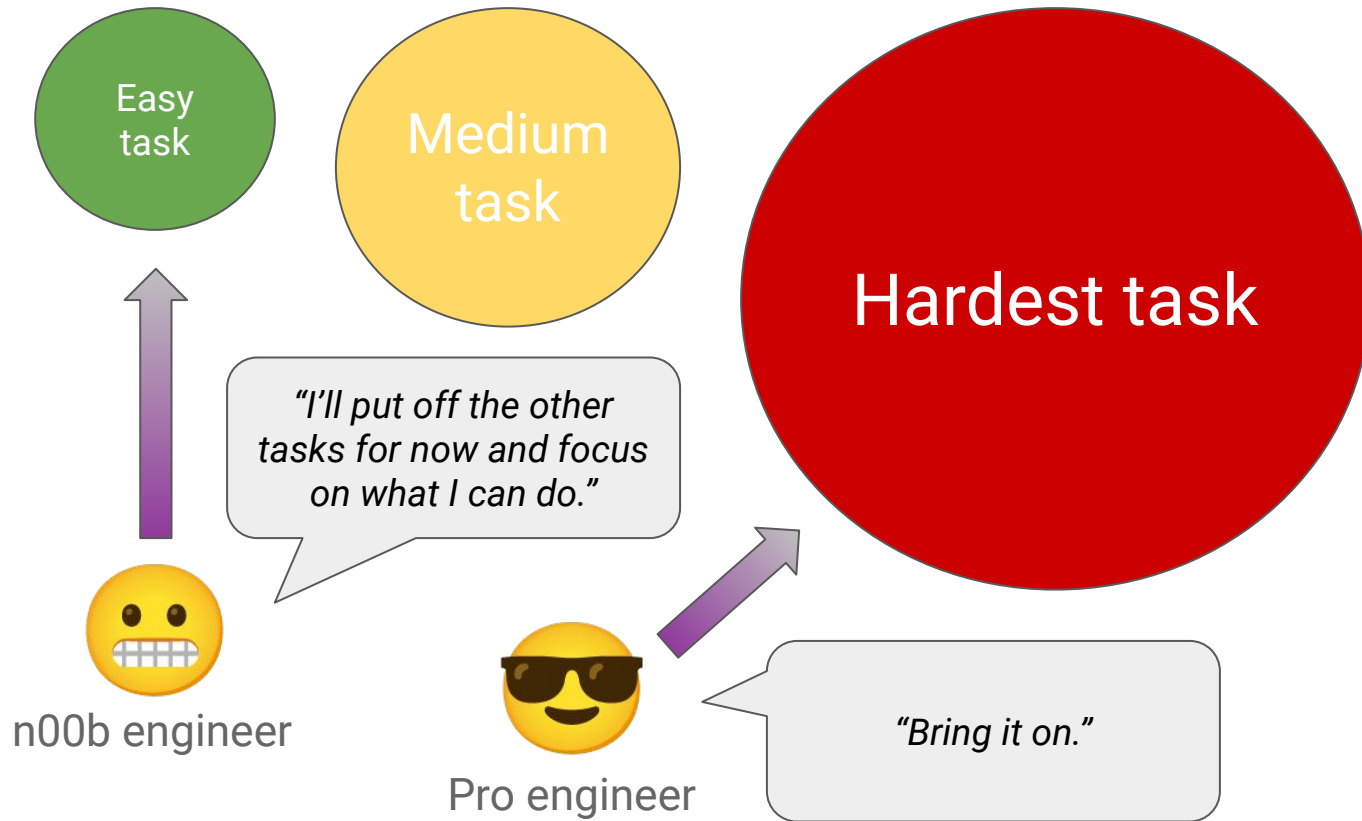


"LET'S GO!!! 🔥"

Do The Hardest Thing First

DO THE
~~EASY~~ HARD
THINGS
FIRST

Parts Of A Project



2 months

Hardest Task

Tackling the hardest problem
first manages risk ✓

3 month deadline

Project

Hardest Task



Project

Hardest Task



Your Team After Doing The Hardest Thing 



Live And Breathe Quality

“It takes less
time to do a
thing right than
to explain why
you did it
wrong.”

- Henry Wadsworth Longfellow





My Mom

*“Alex, there
is no free
lunch”*

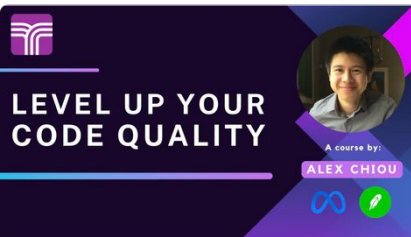
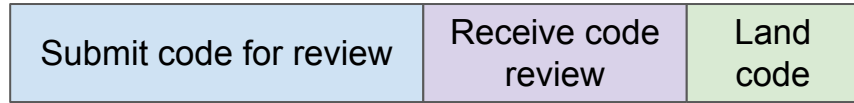


When you cut corners, there will *always* be
consequences eventually 😱

n00b engineer



Pro engineer



Level Up Your Code Quality As A
Software Engineer

Ways To Weave Quality Into Your Work ✨

- 1 *Write good code*
- 2 Communicate well with people, exude positive energy
- 3 Set the agenda for meetings beforehand, take notes
- 4 Flesh out tasks (especially when assigning to others)
- 5 Fix bugs properly (treat root cause, not symptoms)

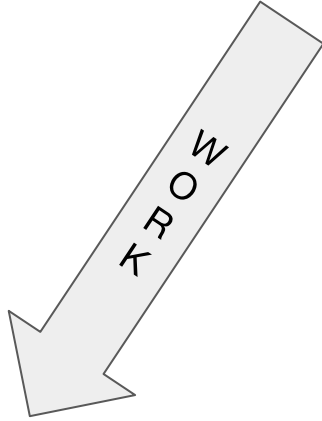
Mentor And Delegate

We Rise by

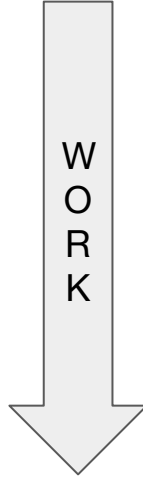
Lifting Others

- Robert Ingersoll

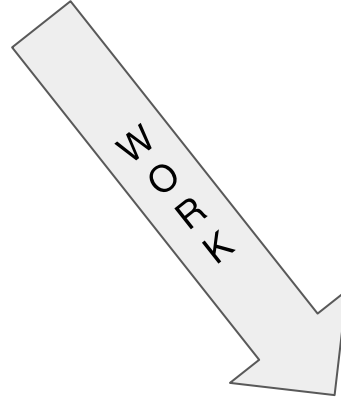




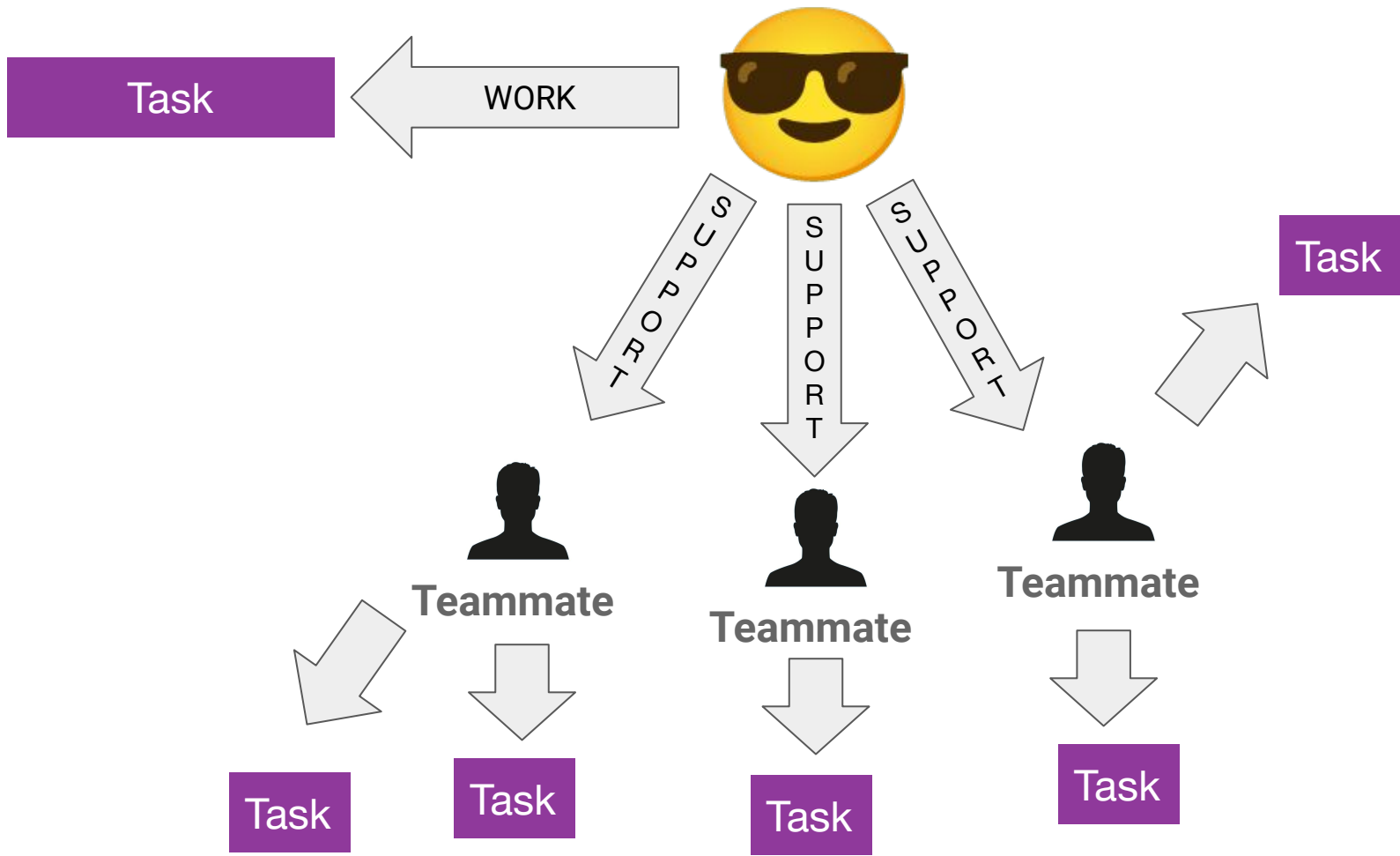
Task



Task



Task



Junior (E3) --> Senior (E5) mentorship



👁 4.9K Views

❤ 74 Likes

✓ Saved

[Case Study] Mentoring Junior SWEs [E3] to Senior [E5] In Just 2.5 Years At Meta

Mentorship: A core ingredient that allowed Alex to not drown at Meta 🙏

Stop Being Lazy

The Demon In Your Pocket

**THE POWER OF
DISTRACTION**

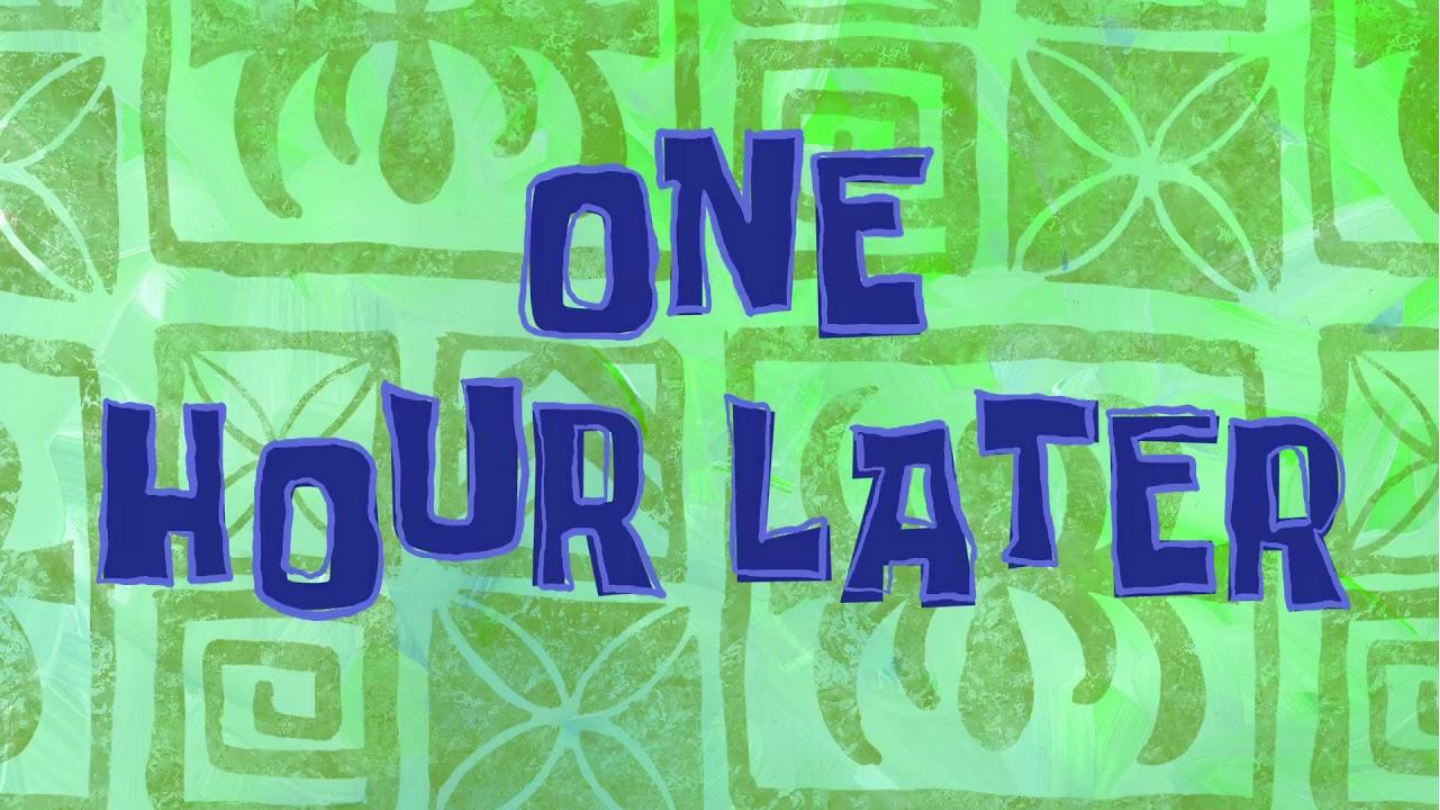




You

*"I'll just check my
phone real quick, see
what's going on."*

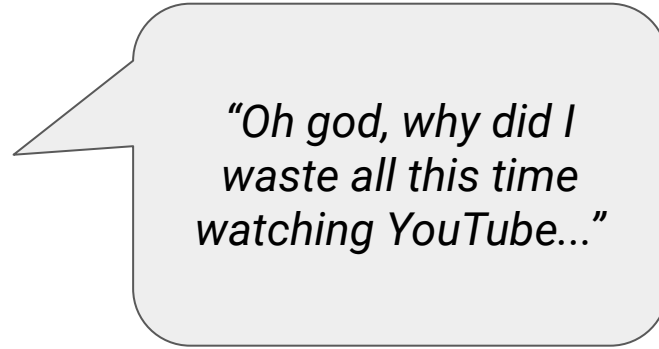




**ONE
HOUR LATER**



You



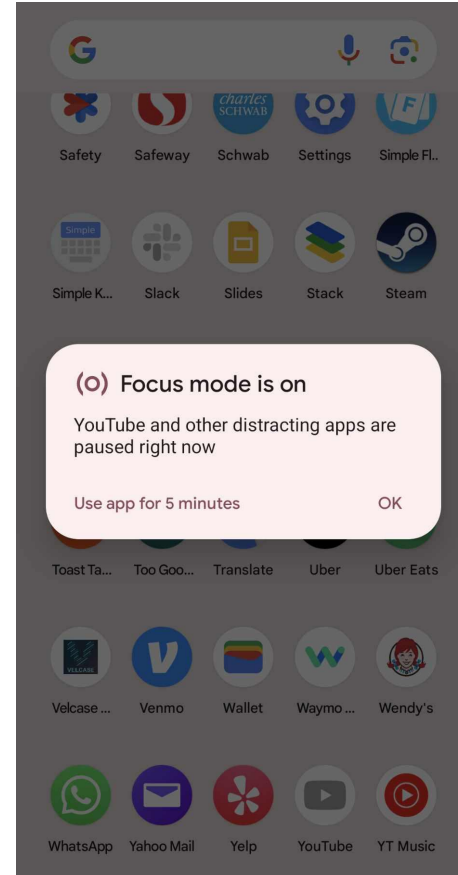
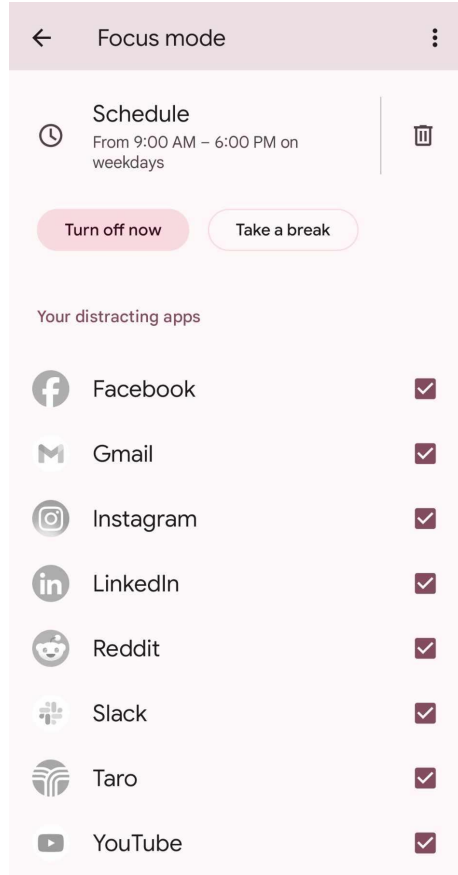
How to fix this? 🛠️

Again, focus on the system ⚙️

Tactic 1: Adding Physical Distance



Tactic 2: Focus Mode



Tactic 3: Lock Box

Cell Phones & Accessories › Accessories



6 VIDEOS



Phone Timed Lock Box, Phone Lock Box with Timer for Android Samsung/Google/ iPhone 15/14/13/13 pro/12/11/X/XR/XS/8/ for Kids/Students/Parents to Unplug from Phones, Video Games, Social Media

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4.4 ★★★★★ ✓ 788 ratings

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50+ bought in past month

\$23⁸⁹

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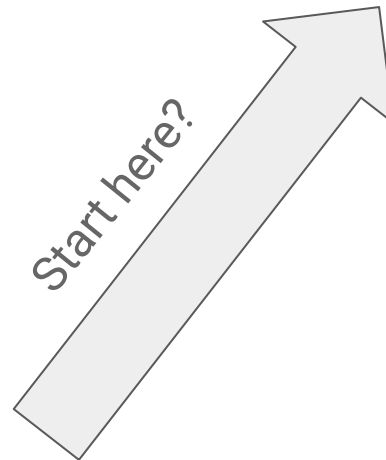
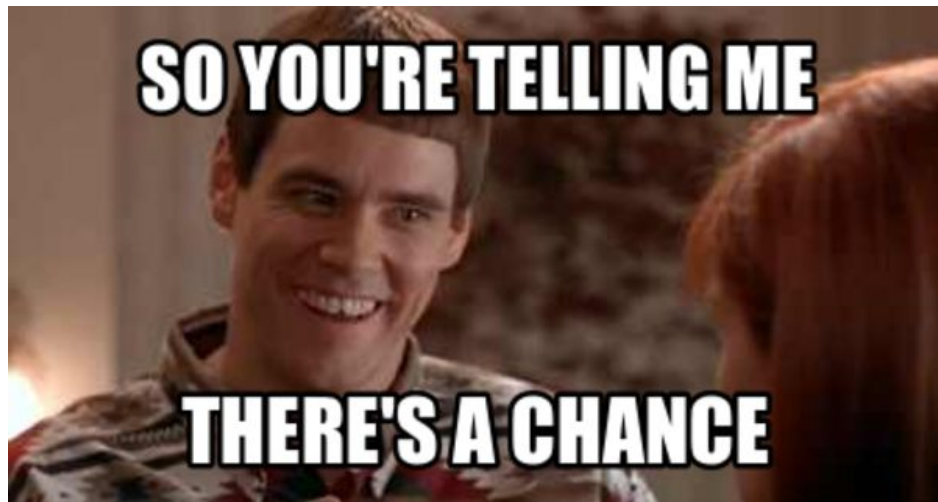
**A little bit of friction goes a long
way.**

Procrastination





Project





Milestone 1

Milestone 2

Milestone 3

Milestone 4

Milestone 5



*"You need to
get some
work done."*

*"You need to
get some
work done."*

*"You need to
get some
work done."*

*"You need to
get some
work done."*

*"You need to
get some
work done."*

*"I should get
started now, so I
don't fall behind."*

Create interstitial points with
due-dates 

These are accountability
checks to prevent laziness 

Following all the advice from this course and still procrastinating? 😓

You probably have a deeper fundamental issue (go through the “Verify Your Foundation” lesson).

Eat The Frog



Set The Tone For The Rest Of The Day

- As soon as the day starts, work on your core task
 - This will often be the hardest thing
 - Forcibly breaks you out of morning state
- Put yourself in an active, go-getter mentality
- Avoid “junk food” tasks
 - Do them around breaks



Junk Food Tasks 🍟

- Checking email 📧
- Going through DMs 💭
- Cleaning out notifications 🔔

Core Tasks 🥗

- Writing code 👩💻
- Creating docs 📄
- Setting up meetings 📅

Just Jump In

JUST DO IT !

WHAT ARE YOU WAITING FOR?

Extended Edition





n00b Engineer



Docs

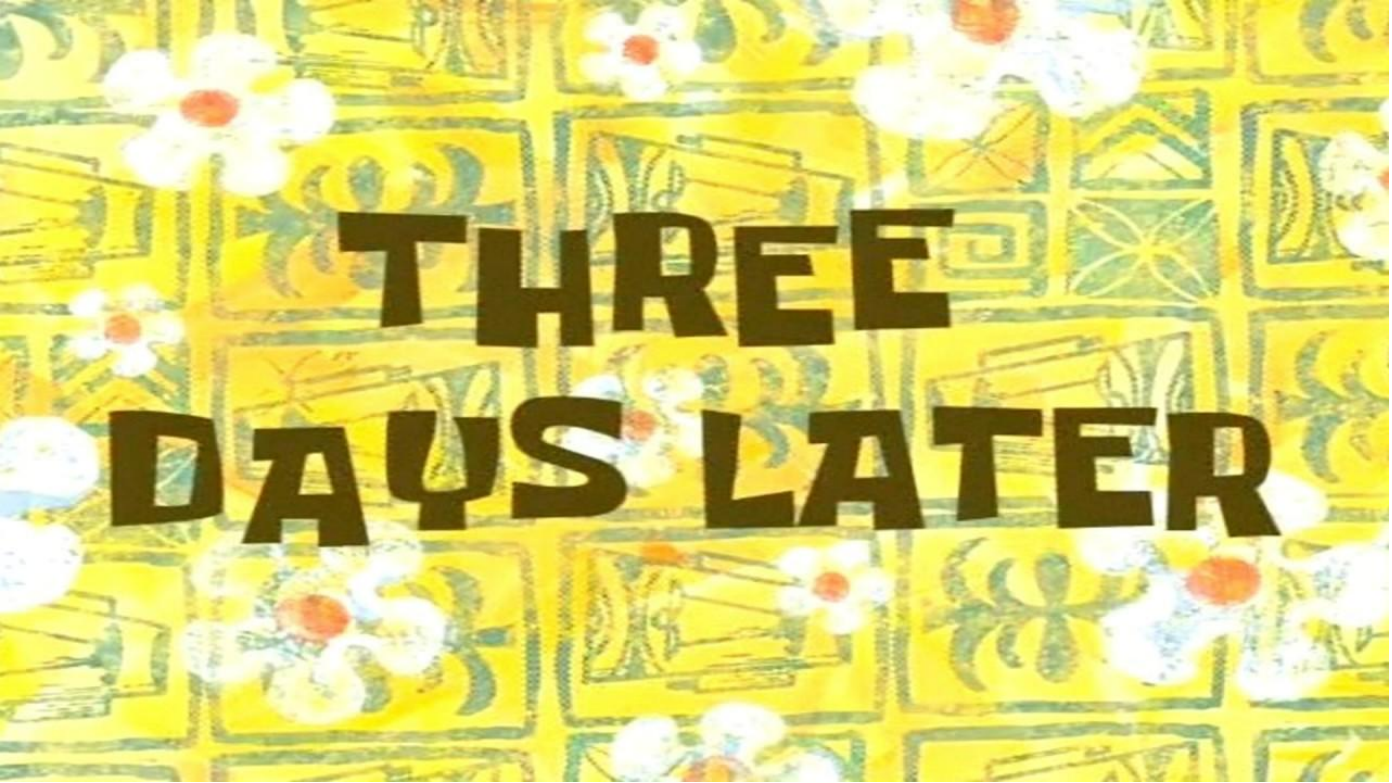


Books



Code

*"I need to read all
this so I can
become ready to
work on the task."*



**THREE
DAYS LATER**



n00b Engineer

"Have you made any progress on the task?"

"I read through a bunch of stuff to learn more about it."

"...so you haven't actually done anything?"



Your Manager

You Will Never Be “Ready”

- Engineering is all about *doing*. Be active instead of passive
 - Consumption is passive
- Bias towards action
 - Writing down a plan
 - Talking to teammates
 - Messing with the code
- Timebox “setup” time



Conclusion

Verify Your Foundation

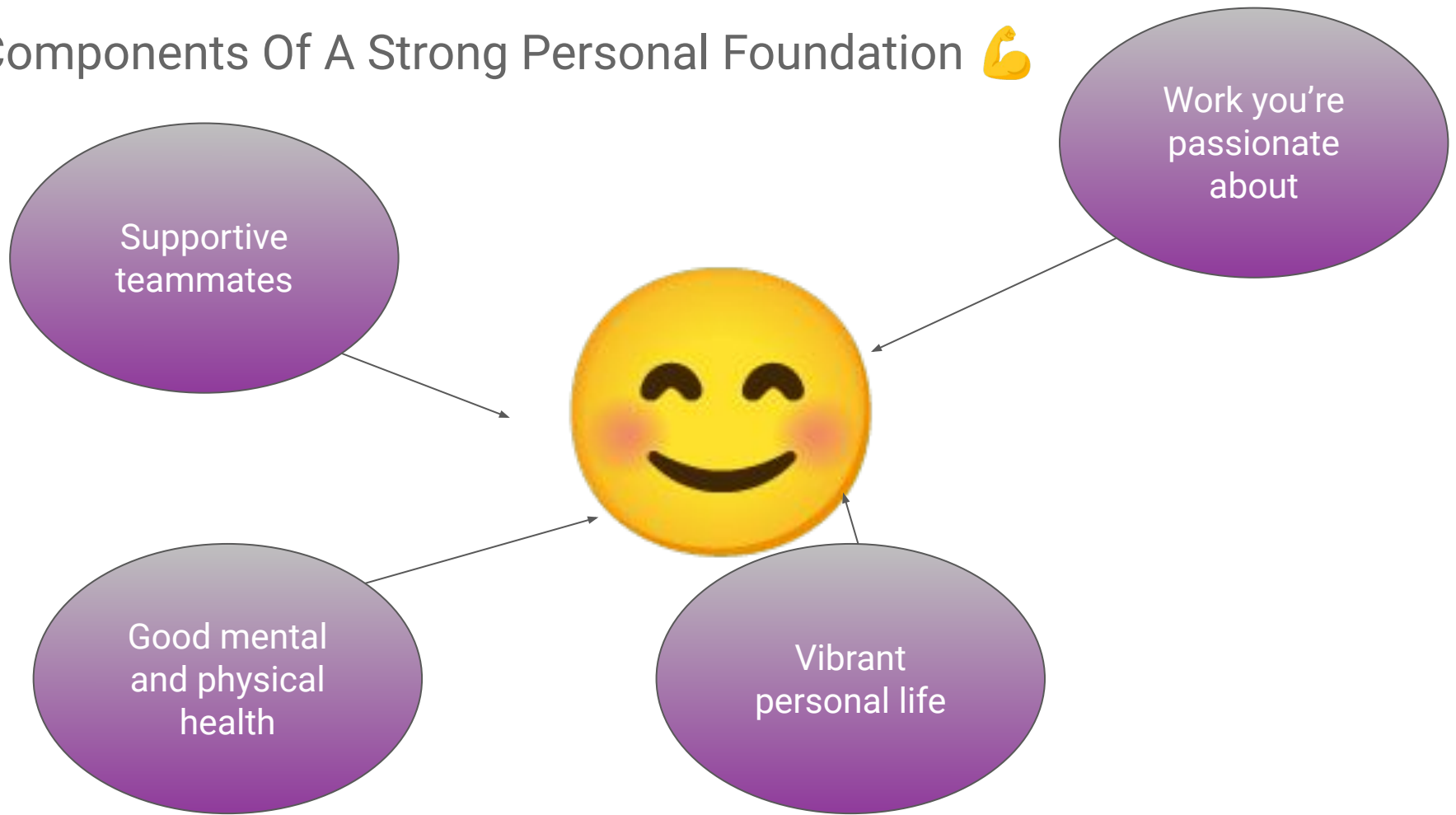


Productivity Is Built Off Of Your Personal Core

- *It's possible to implement all the advice from this course and not be productive*
 - This indicates a deeper issue you must solve
- Productivity fundamentally requires some level of intrinsic **motivation**
- In times of struggle, reflect on your personal foundation



Components Of A Strong Personal Foundation 💪



A person in a blue shirt is seen from behind, holding up a massive, dark, textured rock. The rock is the central focus of the image. The background is a light gray gradient. Two purple text boxes are overlaid on the image. The top box contains the text 'Your Ability To Be Decently Productive' and the bottom box contains 'A Supportive Environment + Healthy Well-Being'.

Your Ability To Be
Decently Productive

A Supportive Environment
+ Healthy Well-Being

Introspect And Reflect



Make Your System Able To Improve Itself

- *You will not get this right on the first try*
 - Healthy habits take a while to build
 - Everybody is different
- Set up time to regularly look inwards to find problems
- The best engineers are honest with themselves



What could
have been
better?

August 2024



Month ▾

	MON 29	TUE 30	WED 31	THU Aug 1	FRI 2 ● 4pm 1 on 1 With Myself (Refle	
	5	6	7	8	9 ● 4pm 1 on 1 With Myself (Refle	
	12	13	14	15	16 ● 4pm 1 on 1 With Myself (Refle	
	19	20	21	22	23 ● 4pm 1 on 1 With Myself (Refle	
	26	27	28	29	30 ● 4pm 1 on 1 With Myself (Refle	

Questions To Ask During Introspection ?

- ① How have things gone since I last did this?
- ② If I wasn't as productive as I wanted to be, why?
- ③ Now that I know why, what can I do to fix the problem?



Action items



Level 1: Write them down

Level 2: Just do them

It's A Never Ending Marathon

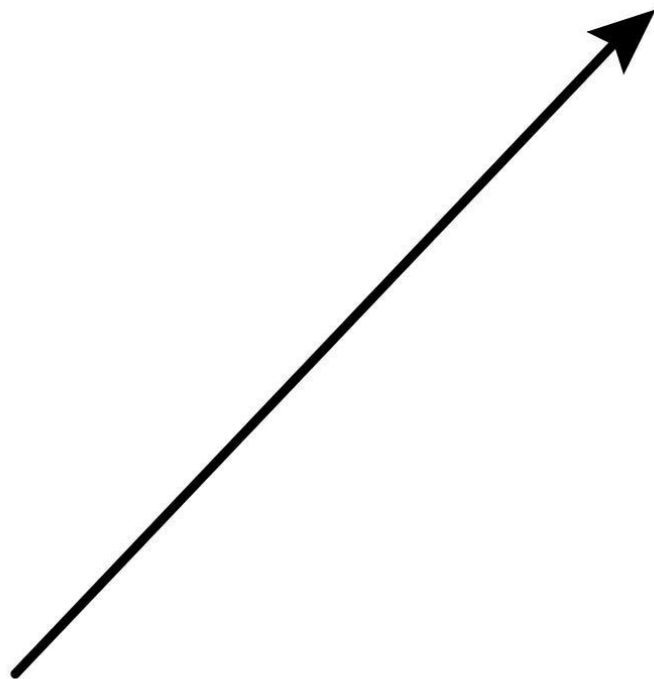


Life is a marathon, not a sprint;
pace yourself accordingly.

Amby Burfoot

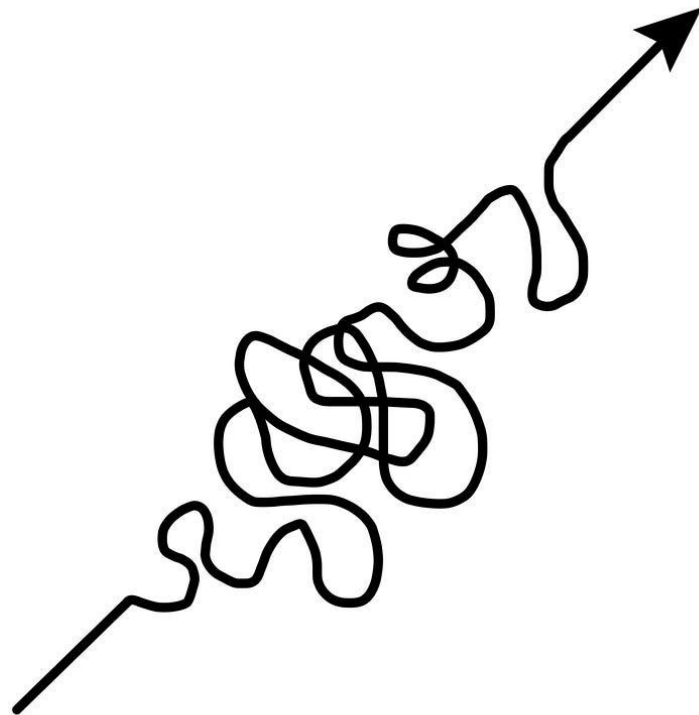
quotefancy

SUCCESS



what people think
it looks like

SUCCESS



what it really
looks like

Greatness Takes Time

- *Productivity will naturally ebb and flow*
 - Even the best engineers are lazy sometimes
- When things look tough, go back to the system. Reflect
- Be comfortable taking 1 step back for 2 steps forward (e.g. taking PTO)
- A little progress is still a win



Go Deeper: Follow Through



Focus on the system, not willpower.

Make time for your personal health.

With quality comes quantity.

Leverage social pressure.

Work on the right things.



Professor Alex's Homework For You

- ❑ Put a recurring meeting on your calendar to reflect
- ❑ Write down everything on your plate and prioritize
- ❑ Organize your calendar and set up a focus block
- ❑ Set up accountability time with colleagues
- ❑ Get better sleep and exercise
- ❑ Kill useless meetings

Network With The World's Best Software Engineers

Meet other people in the community to gain insights, meet for coffee chats, pair up for mock interviews, share referrals, and more!

What company do they work at? ▾

Senior Software Engineer

1

Mock Interviews, Friendly Coffee Chat

2

50 community members match your search



Senior Software Engineer [L5] at Google

San Francisco, California, United States

I'm happy to help with:

Mock Interviews

Connect

Title

I have too many tasks and not enough time - How to deal?

Body

Add more details - the more information you share, the better the community can help you!

H **B** *I* S ☰ ☷ “ </> 🔗



Effective Communication For Engineers



Level Up Your Code Quality As A Software Engineer

thank you 